| AJIT PAWAR | 64 | Deputy Chief Minister, Maharashtra |

# PRIME DEFECTOR

**AJIT PAWAR SPLIT UNCLE SHARAD PAWAR'S NCP TO JOIN A BJP ALLIANCE GOVERNMENT. THE NEW YEAR, WITH TWO BIG ELECTIONS, WILL SHOW WHETHER HE CAN HOLD HIS OWN**

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni





MANDAR DEODHAR

**ON JULY 2, 2023, AJIT ANANTRAO PAWAR** once again proved the old adage about politics being the art of the possible by pivoting away from the source of his power: the original bearer of the name Pawar. Though trying to sugar-coat the rupture ex post facto with overtures to uncle Sharad Pawar, he essentially ditched the political formation the latter's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) had lent its weight to—that too at a delicate hour. Switching to the other side to join the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena-BJP government in Maharashtra, he flipped labels from 'Leader of the Opposition' to 'Deputy CM' in one neat blur of action, wangling the all-important finance portfolio for good measure. Cushy cabinet berths also awaited his merry band of rebels—all eight of them.